

CHILLING COUNT Officials display pictures of victims for identification, (left) bodies lined up at the crash site

AFP

The carnage he would have encountered is evoked by the words of Souvagya Ranjan Sarangi, 25, a pharmacist who runs a small chemist shop near the station, and had the misfortune to witness the crash. "The 'blast' hit me hard in the ears. It felt as if an earthquake had hit Bahanaga. I jumped across the counter and saw some bogies tumbling around." Bhagabat Prasad Rath, whose house was near the station, also heard the explosion and rushed to the spot. "People were wailing loudly," he says, "and I had to negotiate the body parts strewn all over. I saw a well-to-do person crying for help. I helped him get up and he walked some distance resting on my shoulder, but then collapsed right in front of my home and died." Laxmi Narayan Dhal, 52, a cook by profession, survived. He was travelling to Andhra Pradesh, and was in the sleeper coach right behind the engine of the Coromandel Express that rammed into the stationary goods train. "Our bogie was almost flying and I had to hold the handrails tight, as fellow passengers in the packed coach were thrown against me with a gigantic force. I am lucky to be alive," says Dhal, who is being treated for a fracture in the back of his rib cage. Others were not as lucky.

At last count, 288 people had died and close to 1,200 were injured, making this one of the worst crashes in the history of the Indian Railways and forcing us to ask again: how safe is rail travel in India? But first...

WHAT WENT WRONG?

The South Eastern Railway (SER) sector, on which the accident took place, is among the busiest in the country, with a rail utilisation of close to 100 per cent. The layout of the tracks at the dusty Bahanaga Bazar station is typical of how they are laid out at thousands of small stations that dot India's vast railway network of 128,305 km of rail lines. Bahanaga had two main lines (Up and Down) for trains passing through the station without stopping, and two loop lines diverging from these main lines for halting trains. On that fateful evening, both loops had goods trains stationed on them and the trains with passengers were supposed to move only on the main lines. The route boasted the sophisticated Electronic Interlocking System (EIS), the nerve centre of the signalling system of the Indian Railways, for traffic management. Entirely

> The failure of the Station Master and the Signal Inspector to **physically verify that a replaced boom barrier was working fine** was a major cause of the accident